

The AI Investment Landscape and the Best Public-Market Bottleneck Plays

Executive synthesis

The most important conclusion is that the public-market AI opportunity is not, primarily, “buy the app layer.” It is “own the bottlenecks.” The capex engine is being set by Microsoft ¹, Alphabet ², Amazon ³, Meta Platforms ⁴, frontier labs such as OpenAI ⁵ and Anthropic ⁶, and infrastructure leaders such as NVIDIA ⁷ and Broadcom ⁸. The five large tech companies’ capex exceeded \$400 billion in 2025 and is expected to jump another 75% in 2026, according to the International Energy Agency; Reuters also reported that combined AI investment by major U.S. tech companies is on track to exceed \$700 billion in 2026. At the same time, OpenAI said it expects to spend \$50 billion on compute in 2026, while Anthropic reportedly committed \$200 billion over five years to Google Cloud and chips. That spending is the real transmission mechanism from “AI excitement” into durable public-market earnings power. ⁹

That is why the companies with the best risk/reward are the ones supplying scarce, revenue-critical pieces of the stack: memory-interface IP, HBM test and inspection, advanced-packaging metrology, rack-scale connectivity, co-packaged or high-speed interconnect infrastructure, and liquid cooling/power-enablement. These are the places where the customer cannot afford failure, qualification cycles are long, and the supplier often becomes “vendor of choice” across one or more hyperscaler or frontier-lab roadmaps. ¹⁰

My highest-conviction “diamonds in the rough” are Rambus ¹¹, FormFactor ¹², Onto Innovation ¹³, Camtek ¹⁴, and Celestica ¹⁵. My view is that these names offer the best combination of underappreciated strategic position, real operating leverage, and plausible multi-year EV expansion from today’s levels. The highest-quality but less obviously mispriced names are Credo Technology Group Holding Ltd ¹⁶, Astera Labs ¹⁷, Modine Manufacturing Company ¹⁸, and Vertiv ¹⁹. ²⁰

The most important nuance is valuation. Some of the best AI suppliers have already rerated hard. So the goal is not simply “own the best company.” The goal is “own the best bottleneck where the operating trajectory can still outrun the multiple.” In my judgment, the memory-and-advanced-packaging bottleneck basket still has the cleanest setup for that. ²¹

Where the AI profit pool is actually moving

The model layer is spectacular technologically, but economically it is brutal. OpenAI’s reported \$840 billion valuation and Anthropic’s \$380 billion valuation, along with OpenAI’s stated 2026 compute spend and Anthropic’s reported multiyear cloud commitment, make a core point obvious: frontier-model economics are being funded by massive purchases of cloud, chips, memory, networking, and power. Those private valuations may still work for insiders, but for public-market investors the cleaner exposure is often one layer down the stack, where demand is contract-backed and competition is narrower. ²²

The physical constraints are tightening, not loosening. The IEA says AI factories have more than tripled in capacity over the past 18 months; it also flags tightening bottlenecks in electricity, grid connections, advanced-chip manufacturing capacity, and especially high-bandwidth memory, with HBM shortages expected to persist through at least the end of 2027. The U.S. EIA separately forecasts the strongest four-year growth in U.S. electricity demand since 2000, driven largely by data centers. When the bottlenecks are that physical, the margin pool shifts toward the companies that solve those constraints. ²³

That view is reinforced by the large-cap validation layer. TSMC ²⁴ said in its 2025 annual report that AI demand remained robust, that its conviction in the AI megatrend strengthened, that 2nm entered high-volume manufacturing in late 2025, and that advanced packaging technologies such as CoWoS, InFO, and SoIC are core to enabling large-scale interconnectivity. ASML ²⁵ raised its 2026 outlook because customers increased expected short- and medium-term demand. Micron Technology ²⁶ reported record fiscal Q2 2026 results and began HBM4 volume shipments designed for NVIDIA Vera Rubin. Samsung Electronics ²⁷ posted record Q1 2026 revenue and operating profit driven by its memory business. None of those are obscure facts; together they say the same thing: the choke points are leading-edge silicon, advanced packaging, memory, and the infrastructure that lets dense racks run at scale. ²⁸

That is why “AI software winners” and “AI supply-chain winners” should not be treated as interchangeable. In the next three to five years, the better public-market asymmetry is usually in the latter group. The reason is simple: if model competition intensifies, supplier demand can still grow; if capex slows, the software layer also suffers. Suppliers to the bottlenecks have a better chance of getting paid even in a messier competitive environment. ²⁹

The supplier map that matters most

The first bucket is memory and advanced packaging. This is where the next set of underappreciated monopolylike positions sits. HBM stacks, chiplet architectures, CoWoS-like packaging, hybrid bonding, and more complex logic-memory integration all increase the amount of test, inspection, metrology, and interface-IP content per unit of AI compute. This is structurally good for Rambus, FormFactor, Onto Innovation, Camtek, and, in Europe, BE Semiconductor Industries ³⁰. It is also why these companies can grow even if the downstream AI winner changes from NVIDIA to ASICs from Broadcom, hyperscalers, or others. The compute winner can change; the packaging complexity still rises. ³¹

The second bucket is rack-scale connectivity. As clusters move from box scale to rack scale and from rack scale to larger fabrics, the value of reliable retimers, switches, smart cable modules, AECs, and signal-conditioning silicon rises sharply. Astera Labs and Credo are direct beneficiaries of that shift. Astera's current financial profile is extraordinary: Q1 2026 revenue of \$308.4 million, 76.3% GAAP gross margin, and ongoing expansion of its PCIe 6 and AI-fabric portfolio. Credo's profile is also extreme: \$407 million of fiscal Q3 2026 revenue, 68.6% non-GAAP gross margin, and a fifth hyperscaler already contributing to growth. These are not commodity vendors. They are selling into failure-intolerant data paths where power, latency, and reliability all matter. ³²

The third bucket is system integration and manufacturing enablement. Celestica is the best example I found of a company that is not “small” in revenue terms but is still underappreciated by many AI investors. Its Q1 2026 revenue rose 53% to \$4.05 billion, adjusted operating margin hit a record 8.0%, management raised its annual outlook, and it disclosed a hyperscaler co-packaged-optics switch program that is expected to ramp in 2027. In plain English: Celestica is increasingly being trusted to convert AI architecture into shippable

hardware at scale. That position is more defensible than headline gross margin might suggest because qualification, supply-chain execution, and systems knowledge matter a lot once a program is won. ³³

The fourth bucket is power and thermal. AI makes electricity and heat first-order variables. Vertiv's Q4 2025 results showed organic orders up 252% year over year and backlog up 109% to \$15.0 billion, while its own 2026 "Frontiers" report argues that extreme densification, higher-voltage DC architectures, and adaptive liquid cooling are reshaping data-center design. Modine's 10-K shows why second-tier thermal names matter too: climate-solutions sales rose 30% in fiscal 2025, helped by higher data-center cooling sales and significant organic growth to hyperscale and colocation customers, while its product set now spans chillers, CRAH/CRAC, fan walls, and CDUs. That is exactly the kind of "one more hidden tollbooth" exposure investors underrate. ³⁴

Highest-conviction baskets

The scenario ranges below are **illustrative EV MOIC judgments from today's valuation**, not precision target prices. They are here to rank skew, not to pretend to forecast a precise terminal quote.

Memory and advanced-packaging bottleneck basket

Rambus is my favorite truly underappreciated AI-enablement name. The case is that it combines high-margin IP with increasingly tangible product revenue, and both sides of the business benefit from the rise of DDR5, MRDIMM, HBM4/HBM4E, and secure high-speed memory subsystems in AI servers. Rambus reported Q1 2026 product revenue of \$88.0 million, up 15% year over year, launched an HBM4E controller IP that it says builds on more than 100 HBM design wins, and ended the quarter with \$786 million of cash, cash equivalents, and marketable securities. Latest quoted price: about **\$130** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **4.5/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.3x bear / ~2.4x base / ~4.0x bull**. What must be true: HBM4/HBM4E adoption broadens, MRDIMM ramps in 2027+, and Rambus keeps monetizing both IP and chips. Risks: customer insourcing, server-platform timing slips, and the fact that a lot of sentiment is now tied to very visible AI product cycles. ³⁵

FormFactor is the most direct way to own the test bottleneck in HBM and AI networking. Its Q1 2026 release showed record revenue, 49.0% non-GAAP gross margin, record DRAM revenue from stronger HBM demand, and a significant increase in foundry-and-logic demand driven by networking applications. This is the right side of the stack because every HBM generation tends to increase performance requirements and test complexity. Latest quoted price: about **\$145** at the May 5 close. Confidence: **4.0/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.2x bear / ~2.0x base / ~3.2x bull**. What must be true: HBM3 to HBM4 to HBM5 drives more test intensity, and networking/data-center CPU probe-card demand remains firm. Risks: memory cyclicality eventually returns, a customer shifts share, or the market decides the current margin improvement is peak rather than durable. ³⁶

Onto Innovation may be the single best "nobody talks about it enough" name in semicap-adjacent AI. Q1 2026 revenue reached a record \$292 million; the Dragonfly G5 qualified at a leading 2.5D logic customer and an HBM customer; the newly launched Atlas G6 won another logic customer for gate-all-around metrology. The company's relevance is that AI packaging, advanced nodes, and memory each require more process control, not less. Latest quoted price: about **\$305** at the May 5 close. Confidence: **4.0/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.2x bear / ~2.1x base / ~3.3x bull**. What must be true: advanced packaging grows as management expects, Dragonfly and Atlas become broader standards, and spending on metrology stays

attached to both packaging and front-end transitions. Risks: semicap cyclical, slower-than-expected adoption of new tools, or advanced-packaging capex shifting between calendar years. ³⁷

Camtek looks like a classic “small but mission-critical” AI tool vendor. It reported record 2025 revenue of \$496.1 million with 51.6% non-GAAP gross margin, expects another double-digit growth year in 2026, received more than \$90 million of Q1 2026 orders from leading OSATs largely for CoWoS-like AI packaging, and separately announced a \$45 million aggregate Hawk order stream from a tier-1 IDM for AI applications. That is exactly what you want to see from an overlooked supplier. Latest quoted price: about **\$203** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **4.0/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.2x bear / ~2.3x base / ~3.6x bull**. What must be true: advanced packaging and HBM inspection intensity continues rising, OSATs keep taking more of the AI-packaging mix, and Camtek retains its technology edge in 2D/3D metrology. Risks: China exposure, regional geopolitics around Israel ³⁸, a faster move by larger competitors, or a normalization in AI packaging order cadence after a capacity burst. ³⁹

Besi is the optional non-U.S. kicker in this basket. In Q1 2026 it posted 104.5% year-over-year order growth, with hybrid-bonding orders more than doubling versus Q4 and management explicitly linking the strength to next-generation AI applications and HBM memory customers. If hybrid bonding becomes as universal in AI packaging as many in the industry expect, Besi could wind up being one of the cleanest pure plays on that transition. Confidence: **3.5/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.1x bear / ~2.2x base / ~4.0x bull**. What must be true: hybrid bonding actually moves from qualification into broad commercial adoption across logic, HBM, and optics between 2027 and 2030. Risks: timing; hybrid bonding has already taken longer than many expected, and the stock is no longer obscure. ⁴⁰

Rack-scale connectivity and systems basket

Credo Technology is the best “Ethernet wins more of AI than the market thinks” vehicle. Its fiscal Q3 2026 results showed \$407 million of revenue and 68.6% non-GAAP gross margin; management said demand was driven by substantial growth across four domestic hyperscalers, that a fifth hyperscaler win is now contributing, and that the company continues to expect three to four customers above 10% of revenue in coming quarters. Its 10-K says one customer accounted for 67% of fiscal 2025 revenue and that it is engaged with all major hyperscalers. That concentration is a risk, but it also proves strategic relevance. Latest quoted price: about **\$198** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **3.8/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~0.9x bear / ~1.9x base / ~3.0x bull**. What must be true: AECs remain a preferred answer for a meaningful part of scale-out networking, optics becomes additive rather than purely cannibalistic, and Credo broadens beyond its largest customers without losing share. Risks: co-packaged optics or alternative topologies erode the copper/AEC opportunity faster than expected; valuation is no longer forgiving. ⁴¹

Astera Labs is a superb business, but I rate it as slightly less asymmetric than Rambus/FormFactor/Onto/Camtek only because the stock has already had such a major rerating. Even so, its strategic position is exceptional. It reported Q1 2026 revenue of \$308.4 million with 76.3% GAAP gross margin; its 10-K says its top three end customers were about 86% of 2025 revenue and one end customer was over 70%; the filing also shows customer warrants with Amazon, and the company has explicit product collaborations around NVIDIA MGX Blackwell platforms and the NVLink Fusion ecosystem. In other words, this is already inside the architectures that matter. Latest quoted price: about **\$214** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **3.8/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~0.8x bear / ~1.7x base / ~2.8x bull**. What must be true: rack-scale PCIe/CXL and AI-fabric complexity continues to rise, Astera converts design engagements into broad share, and custom-solutions

revenue becomes meaningful rather than niche. Risks: customer concentration, customer insourcing, or a future architecture shift away from the standards Astera is currently monetizing. ⁴²

Celestica is the one name in this report that I think many “AI semiconductor” investors still structurally under-own because they mentally bucket it as an EMS company. That is too simplistic. Celestica’s current role is deeply tied to hyperscaler AI compute and networking platforms, and management has repeatedly framed demand as durable into 2027. The company just posted 53% Q1 2026 revenue growth, an 8.0% adjusted operating margin, and disclosed a co-packaged-optics switch program for a hyperscaler that ramps in 2027. Latest quoted price: about **\$418** at the May 5 close. Confidence: **4.2/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.0x bear / ~1.8x base / ~2.7x bull**. What must be true: Celestica keeps winning not just build-to-print capacity but higher-value system-integration and networking programs. Risks: lower gross margins than pure semiconductor names, supplier constraints limiting growth, and the possibility that hyperscalers rebalance program share among ODM/OEM partners. ⁴³

Power and thermal basket

Modine Manufacturing is a much better AI name than many investors realize because it gives exposure to the physical cooling layer without requiring everything to funnel through a single premium infrastructure vendor. Its annual report shows significant organic sales growth to hyperscale and colocation customers and a product suite that now includes chillers, CRAH/CRAC units, fan walls, and CDUs. That is exactly the mix that becomes more valuable as rack densities rise. Latest quoted price: about **\$274** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **3.7/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~1.0x bear / ~1.8x base / ~2.8x bull**. What must be true: liquid cooling becomes structural rather than a temporary project wave, and Modine’s move toward being a pure-play climate-solutions company improves the quality multiple. Risks: execution risk in capacity expansion, competition from larger HVAC/data-center players, and the fact that the stock is no longer obscure. ⁴⁴

Vertiv is no longer overlooked, but it remains one of the cleanest ways to own the thermal-and-power complexity of AI factories. Organic orders grew 252% in Q4 2025 and backlog reached \$15.0 billion; management argues that higher-voltage DC architectures and adaptive liquid cooling are reshaping the entire data-center design stack. Latest quoted price: about **\$359** at the May 6 close. Confidence: **4.2/5**. Illustrative EV MOIC: **~0.9x bear / ~1.4x base / ~1.9x bull**. What must be true: AI densification endures, and Vertiv’s mix keeps shifting toward higher-value integrated solutions and services. Risks: the stock already discounts a lot, and any cooling commoditization or capex digestion would hit sentiment quickly. ⁴⁵

What has to stay true for generational returns

The first condition is that AI spending must remain a **compute-and-infrastructure arms race**, not just a short training cycle. The evidence today supports that view: hyperscaler capex continues rising, AI-factory capacity is exploding, and OpenAI and Anthropic are still making gigantic compute commitments. If that changes materially, the whole thesis weakens. ⁴⁶

The second condition is that **HBM and advanced packaging remain scarce for longer than the market expects**. Today, the IEA explicitly says HBM shortages are expected to persist through at least the end of 2027. TSMC, Micron, Samsung, Camtek, Onto, and Besi collectively reinforce that packaging/memory complexity is rising, not falling. This is the single most important reason I favor the memory-and-packaging basket. ⁴⁷

The third condition is that **Ethernet and open interconnect ecosystems capture a large share of scale-out networking**, even if proprietary scale-up systems remain important. If a very small number of proprietary fabrics capture nearly all value, Credo and parts of Astera's opportunity set would narrow. If open Ethernet/PCIe/CXL/UALink-style ecosystems continue broadening, their runway is longer. Astera's PCIe 6 and NVLink Fusion positioning and Credo's "fifth hyperscaler" expansion both support that case, but it is still a live competitive battleground. ⁴⁸

The fourth condition is that **liquid cooling and power redesign become standard infrastructure**, not a niche solution for only the very densest deployments. Vertiv, Modine, and adjacent names work best if the whole industry shifts from "air until proven otherwise" to "liquid where practical and increasingly by default." Everything from the IEA's energy analysis to Vertiv's own roadmap suggests that is where things are going. ⁴⁹

The fifth condition is that **the AI capex cycle broadens beyond the current handful of hyperscalers**. TSMC explicitly talks about sovereign AI, and the current project pipeline already includes neoclouds, national buildouts, and enterprise inference infrastructure. The broader the customer base becomes, the more durable the supplier theses are because dependence on any one hyperscaler declines over time. ⁵⁰

Competition, displacement, and geopolitical risk

The biggest competitive risk is not "AI goes away." It is **value migrating to a different layer of the stack**. For example, if custom ASICs from Broadcom, hyperscalers, or others gain share against NVIDIA GPUs, that is not necessarily bad for Rambus, FormFactor, Onto, Camtek, Modine, Vertiv, or Celestica; in many cases it is neutral to good because those names monetize complexity rather than a single compute brand. It is more ambiguous for Astera and Credo, where protocol choice, cable topology, and system architecture matter more directly. ⁵¹

The second risk is **technological substitution inside interconnects**. AECs can be displaced at the margin by optical approaches, co-packaged optics, or other scaling solutions. That matters most for Credo. Celestica's disclosed CPO switch program is a reminder that the optical transition is not theoretical. In other words, some beneficiaries of AI scale-out are also potential disruptors of adjacent AI scale-out vendors. This is why I like buying the basket instead of making a single all-or-nothing call on one interconnect topology. ⁵²

The third risk is **policy and geopolitics**. Supply chains remain heavily concentrated in Taiwan ⁵³ and broader Asia, while the U.S. keeps altering export-control and tariff rules around advanced semiconductors. BIS has extended the approved-IC-designer timeline and the White House has also issued semiconductor tariff actions; Reuters reports that the U.S. withdrew one proposed AI-chip export rule in March 2026 while separately adjusting China-related controls. China, meanwhile, has been building out and enforcing its own export-control toolkit. This does not break the AI thesis, but it increases the value of suppliers with diversified geography, strong compliance capabilities, or onshoring tailwinds in the United States ⁵⁴ . ⁵⁵

The fourth risk is **energy and grid availability**. The IEA and EIA are effectively telling investors that electricity is becoming a gating factor for AI. If grid bottlenecks worsen, some projects slip. That is bad for the near-term buildout rate, but it is also why thermal, power, and prefabricated-infrastructure suppliers can continue to gain strategic importance. It is a timing risk, not necessarily a thesis killer. ⁵⁶

Portfolio construction and final investment view

If I were building a public-market AI bottleneck basket today, I would not make it a pure “best known AI infrastructure names” portfolio. I would make it a **barbell**.

On one side, I would hold the **highest-upside overlooked bottleneck names**: Rambus, FormFactor, Onto Innovation, Camtek, and Celestica. Those are the names where I think the market still underestimates how much of the AI profit pool can accrue to test, metrology, inspection, memory-interface IP, and systems integration. They are also the names where I see the most plausible **3x to 5x bull-case EV MOICs** over a full cycle, especially if HBM shortages and advanced-packaging intensity last into the back half of the decade.

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On the other side, I would own the **higher-quality, somewhat less mispriced enablers**: Credo, Astera, Modine, and Vertiv. These are more recognized winners, so upside is less explosive from current levels, but their strategic positions are very real. In practice, they reduce the odds that the overall basket misses the AI buildout simply because one bottleneck theme takes longer than expected.

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My single strongest conviction call is this: **the most durable AI profits over the next several years are likely to accrue to suppliers of scarcity, not suppliers of hope**. Scarcity today means HBM-related IP, advanced-packaging test and inspection, rack-scale connectivity, hyperscaler-grade manufacturing execution, and liquid-cooling/power infrastructure. That is why my favorite “nuggets worth pursuing” are Rambus, FormFactor, Onto Innovation, Camtek, and Celestica, with Besi as a high-beta international add and Astera/Credo as excellent but more fully appreciated names.

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Open questions and limitations

This report is based on a broad but still selective review of the highest-signal primary materials I could gather quickly: current earnings releases, SEC filings or annual reports, and the most relevant earnings-call transcripts and industry/policy documents. It is therefore **rigorous but not literally exhaustive across every AI-adjacent public company**. Share prices are dynamic; where I cite a “current” price, I am using the latest close or latest quoted level visible in the sources at the time of research, not a guaranteed real-time executable quote. The EV MOIC ranges are **illustrative scenario judgments**, intended to rank upside and risk rather than serve as precise valuation targets.

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